Use biometrics for convenience, but remember that the PIN or password is the foundation. Avoid obvious PINs: birth year, vehicle number, house number, 0000, 1234, 2580, anniversary dates or anything printed on your social media life. Patterns are often easy to shoulder-surf, especially if the screen is smudged. A six-digit PIN is a reasonable minimum. A longer alphanumeric password is stronger, though less convenient.

Also reduce the screen lock timeout. A phone that stays unlocked for five minutes after you put it down is a security problem wearing a battery-saving excuse.

Step-by-step: strengthen your screen lock

- Open Settings.
- Search Screen lock.
- Choose PIN, Password or a secure option available on your phone.
- Set at least a six-digit PIN if using numbers.
- Add fingerprint unlock after setting the PIN.
- Add face unlock only if your phone's implementation is reliable enough for your comfort.
- Search Lock after screen timeout or Automatically lock.
- Set a short lock delay.
- Test by locking and unlocking the phone several times.

This is basic, but basic is what thieves, pranksters and opportunists first encounter.

Secure the SIM, not just the phone

Many users forget that the SIM is a security device. It receives OTPs, UPI verification messages, banking alerts and account recovery codes. If someone removes your SIM from a stolen phone and puts it into another device, your phone lock alone may not be enough.

Enable a SIM PIN if you are comfortable managing it responsibly. A SIM PIN is required when the SIM is inserted into a new device or after restart, depending on behaviour. But be careful: entering the wrong SIM PIN repeatedly can lock the SIM and require the PUK code from the operator. Store the correct information safely before experimenting.

For dual-SIM Indian users, know which SIM is linked to banks, UPI, Aadhaar services, email recovery and WhatsApp. Label them clearly in Android settings. Security begins with knowing which number matters.

Turn on Play Protect

Google Play Protect is Android's built-in app safety layer. Google says Play Protect checks apps when they are installed, periodically scans the device, warns about potentially harmful apps, and may disable or remove harmful apps when detected. It can also warn about unsafe apps or URLs and scan unknown apps from outside Google Play.

This does not make you invincible, but leaving it off is foolish. Think of Play Protect as the guard at the gate. A guard does not stop every crime in the city, but you still want one at the entrance.

Step-by-step: check Play Protect

- Open the Play Store.
- Tap your profile picture.
- Tap Play Protect.
- Check whether scanning is on.
- Tap Settings inside Play Protect.
- Turn on app scanning.
- Enable improved harmful app detection if you are comfortable sending unknown app details to Google for analysis.
- Run a manual scan.

If Play Protect warns you about an app, do not casually dismiss the warning just because the app looks useful.

Treat APKs like unknown food

Android lets users install apps from outside the Play Store. This openness is useful. It also creates one of the easiest ways to compromise a phone.

Search Unknown app installs in Settings. Browsers, file managers, messaging apps and cloud storage apps may request permission to install APKs. Keep this permission off by default. If you must install a trusted APK, enable it temporarily, install, then disable it again.

Google is also tightening sideloading. It has announced developer identity verification requirements for apps distributed outside Play in certified Android environments, beginning in some countries in September 2026 and expanding globally from 2027, according to recent reporting.

Find Hub before panic arrives

A lost phone is not only a lost device. It is a lost wallet, camera, ID folder, work terminal and authentication token. Google's Find